

Watson Franklin Hartsoe III

PhD Candidate, Digital Media — Georgia Institute of Technology — Advisor: Jay David Bolter

watson.hartsoe@gmail.com · GitHub · YouTube · Medium

PROFILE

Generative media research depends on prompt-driven systems but still treats prompts as informal inputs. Watson Hartsoe's work addresses this by studying prompts, prompt-output pairs, and prompt sequences as media objects. His dissertation argues that generative AI turns description into an operative medium. His method — thick prompting — converts that claim into a research procedure through documented variation, comparison, and explicit reporting limits. Across browser-based tools, AI filmmaking, semantic-to-spatial systems, and collaborative projects, he builds semantic instruments that make generative workflows inspectable and revisable.

EDUCATION

Georgia Institute of Technology

PhD Candidate, Digital Media · Dissertation: operative description, thick prompting, imagetext-to-worldtext

Emory University — Research Collaborator, 2023–2024

Co-developed graduate cybernetics curriculum. Interdisciplinary work connecting cybernetics, media theory, systems theory, and cultural critique.

ACCEPTED WORK

ACCEPTED

Ripples — Exhibition + Talk (two submissions)

ELO 2026 (Un)Supervised · Electronic Literature Organization

With Terhi Marttila (LARSyS) and Jay David Bolter. Distant writing via generative AI. Hartsoe's branch: unsupervised legibility. Talk: distant writing as ecological orchestration. Draft

ACCEPTED

Treating Workers Like Guided Missile Pigeons

HWID 2026 · IFIP WG 13.6 · Univ. of West London · June 2026 · Pending revisions

Solo author. "Thick Machine" and "Behavioural Control Networks" as lenses for AI-mediated labour. Reviewer: "The interdisciplinary grounding and historical analysis are strengths."

AWARDS

Hackathon Winner — Georgia Tech AI Competition

WAGY0 · AI-assisted VR development · \$10,000 prize

Winner — AI for GOOD 2024

Guardian of Mercy · Collaborative humanitarian AI film · Video

Tech Arts Grant — THEM 641

Public Archive of AI Love · Archive

Semi-Finalist — Neu Wave AI Film Festival

MESA CHIP · Gallery

Finalist — Project Odyssey Season 1

Dancing Cactus Cowboy · AI film

CREATIVE WORK

Where You Go When You Leave — Feature Film

Chief AI Operations · With poet Mark Anthony Thomas · Festival circuit 2026

Built generative production pipeline from prompt to final render. Seeking distribution.

Resurrecting Atlantis

Multi-year collaboration with Thomas · 20,125 files · 112.68 GB · Presented at Georgia Tech

Fusion

Audit

Atlantis

Hot Minute

Out of Life

Blue Deli / Blue Belt Films

Collaborative AI filmmaking infrastructure · Matrix Editor, World Prompt, emergent narrative

RESEARCH LINEAGE

- 1 **LEGOS**
Narrative grammar (Location, Entity, Goal, Obstacle, Shift, Solution). Presented at Transformer Conference.
- 2 **Ethics Infrastructure**
Prompts as executable specs. Ethics in the build system. Developed through Richmond Wong's project studio.
- 3 **WAG — Words Assemble Geometry**
Semantic fidelity through compilation. Language as executable spatial specification.
- 4 **ABC-FLIX / ICARO**
Temporal evidence. Prompt-driven media as sequence, not just output. Bell Lab lineage.
- 5 **Shield of Achilles → Worldtext**
Co-authored with Bolter. Ekphrastic description becomes operational inside generative pipeline.

PUBLICATIONS & DRAFTS

From Imagetext to Worldtext: Generative AI as Operative Ekphrasis

With Jay David Bolter · Core dissertation anchor

WAG Protocols for Semantic-to-Spatial Compilation

Dec 2024 · Ethics · WAG

Thick Prompting: An Interpretive Method for Studying Generative AI Interaction

Method draft · Dissertation center

Probabilistic Cultural Systems Ontology

Completed · Demo

Reflective Design for Informal Participatory Algorithm Auditing

Submitted to NordiCHI 2024 · Collaborative

"Machine Gun and Soul(less)" / "Play, Freedom, and AI Films"

Conference posters 2024 · With Cecile Zhang

The Myth Engine / Poetic Latency

SIGGRAPH DAC SPARKS 2026 · Two talk proposals

SELECTED INSTRUMENTS

- Operation-Describe — executable ekphrasis
- TRACTOR / WAG — spatial compilation
- ABC-FLIX / ICARO — motion harness
- Pretext Field — cognitive cartography
- Twine Bridge — humanities access
- MOTO — sound / broadcast
- Ripples — browser motion
- Mythos Canon — myth as OS
- Ecology of Media — philosophical core
- Sense Ritual — playable prompts

COLLABORATORS

- Jay David Bolter — Advisor. Co-author.
- Mark Anthony Thomas — Poet. Film + Atlantis.
- Terhi Marttila — LARSyS. ELO co-author.
- Richmond Wong — Ethics / project studio.
- Cecile Zhang — AI film posters.
- Jordan Caldwell — Experience design.
- Kayla Uleah Evans — Ethics in NLP.
- Shuruq Tramontini — Emergent sims.
- So-youn Jang — Latent space.

SERVICE

- Mentor — Georgia Tech Art & AI VIP Program
Undergraduate research on generative critique and AI media systems.
- Workshop Leader — Transformer 2025
AI narrative design, speculative interfaces, generative media practice.
- Facilitator — RunwayML Gen48 AI Filmmaking Team
Collaborative AI filmmaking workflows and rapid creative production.

Annual Progress Report — 2025–2026

Watson Franklin Hartsoe III · PhD Candidate, Digital Media · Georgia Institute of Technology

Digital media research now faces an unstable object: the prompt. The field uses prompt-driven systems to generate images, video, worlds, interfaces, and stories, but it treats the prompt as a temporary input rather than as part of the media object under analysis. If the prompt shapes production, constraint, revision, and interpretation, then ignoring the prompt-output relation means ignoring the mechanism through which the artifact came to exist.

My work this year addressed that instability by narrowing a broad creative practice into a focused dissertation problem. Across AI filmmaking, semantic-to-spatial tools, ethics interfaces, narrative engines, and media-theoretical writing, I identified one recurring failure: description is still discussed as if it stands outside production, although in generative systems it acts within production.

I frame this as **operative description**. A prompt does not only request an artifact. It specifies relations, activates systems, constrains outputs, organizes revisions, and leaves a trace that changes how the output should be interpreted. The cost of missing this is methodological: researchers risk analyzing generated artifacts as isolated objects while leaving out the language-mediated operation that produced them.

The method I developed is **thick prompting**. It treats prompt-output pairs and prompt sequences as evidence-bearing media objects, studying them through documented variation, logging, comparison, interpretive criteria, and explicit reporting limits. Its purpose is not to teach better prompting. Its purpose is to make generative media interaction analyzable without collapsing into hype, anecdote, or platform-specific technique.

What changed this year. The major progress was not more artifacts — it was the establishment of hierarchy. Earlier versions carried too many centers: myth, ecology, AI film, cybernetics, archives, agents, ethics, prompts, world-building, tools. The current version is more defensible because those elements now have roles:

Operative description is the claim.

Thick prompting is the method.

Prompt-output pairs and prompt sequences are the evidence objects.

WAG, Ethics Infrastructure, Shield, LEGOS, ABC-FLIX are supporting cases.

The larger creative portfolio is context, not the dissertation.

Strongest evidence. *From Imagetext to Worldtext*, developed with Jay David Bolter, provides the media-theoretical anchor — connecting the work to word-image theory and framing generative AI as a shift from prompt-and-image toward prompt-and-world construction. *WAG* is the strongest practice-based evidence that description becomes construction: it treats language as executable spatial specification and routes prompts through planning, compilation, inspectable world files, and browser rendering. *Ethics Infrastructure*, developed through Richmond Wong's project studio, gives the argument its accountability edge — if prompts operate media systems, then ethical constraints must be built into workflow and interface states. *Shield of Achilles* works as bounded case material: ekphrastic description becoming operational inside a generative pipeline.

Creative practice and recognition. The feature film *Where You Go When You Leave*, produced as Chief AI Operations with poet Mark Anthony Thomas, is seeking festival distribution. *Resurrecting Atlantis* represents a multi-year, 112 GB creative pipeline with Thomas — hundreds of thousands of generations building production workflows with poets, not over one session but over years. Additional recognition includes the WAGYO hackathon win (\$10K), AI for GOOD 2024 (Guardian of Mercy), Tech Arts Grant (THEM 641), and Neu Wave AI Film Festival semi-finalist (MESA CHIP). Two submissions were accepted at ELO 2026 with Marttila and Bolter; one paper was accepted at HWID 2026.

Current dissertation position. The dissertation asks how language functions when it operates generative media systems. Its claim is that prompts are operative descriptions. Its method is thick prompting. Its evidence is bounded: selected prompt sequences, one or two demonstration cases, and explicit reporting limits. The dissertation is not a theory of all AI, all creativity, or all media. It is a focused account of a specific instability: the field relies on prompt-output systems while lacking a sufficiently precise method for analyzing the relation between the prompt, the generated artifact, and the workflow that connects them.

Next step: proposal compression. One claim, one method, a bounded corpus. The claim is operative description. The method is thick prompting. The corpus focuses on prompt-output sequences and carefully selected demonstrations. The broader creative portfolio remains valuable, but the dissertation must stay disciplined enough for a committee to repeat it back in one sentence.